EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Can You Just Learn and Pray All Day?

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 10:14-17

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 10 (How a Person Should Conduct Himself in This World), Chapters 14 to 17: wisdom, worship, rest, and the right combination, opening with a discussion of free will from the end of Chapter 13

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 5 January 2026, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

The Plan for the Last Weeks

The first Monday shiur after the winter break. The plan:

- **Tonight:** Chapters 14, 15 and 16, the last three of the thirteen extremes (and, as it turned out, Chapter 17 too).
- **Next week:** Chapters 18 and 19, completing the sefer.
- **The week after:** a summary of the entire sefer, a small celebration, and a decision on the new Monday sefer. The Rabbi was considering the Moreh Nevuchim, the Kuzari, and HaMaspik l'Ovdei Hashem by Rabbeinu Avraham, the Rambam's son.

The other shiurim continue as usual: the Rambam's Principles of Faith on Tuesday (up to the sixth principle) and Hilchot Shabbat on Thursday.

Recap: ten extremes so far

In the tenth essay Saadia is teaching how important balance is: never to take even important things alone. So far: abstinence, eating and drinking, intimacy, passion, accumulating wealth, having many children, building up the world, long life, power and authority, and revenge. Tonight: **חכמה**, wisdom; **עבודה**, worship; and **מנוחה**, tranquility. "Each of these things have their places, but they're not to be taken alone."

Part 1: Can a Person Harm Someone Hashem Has Not Decreed Should Be Harmed?

Before the break the Rabbi had flagged one sentence at the end of the chapter on revenge, connected to the recent parshiot and the subject of a *machloket*.

ומה תוחלת הנכזבה לעמוד כנגד בורא השמים והארץ, כדברינו אנחנו אנשי האמת

What false hope it is to stand against the Creator of heaven and earth, according to us, the people of truth. Why take revenge, when everything is in Hashem's hands? The implication: if Hashem has decreed something for a person, no one else can change it.

Saadia is explicit in Essay 4

Saadia says this even more clearly in the fourth essay, on free will. If A kills B, A has done wrong, but why is it fair to B?

המות מעשה האלהים וההרג מעשה העול, ובחכמה חייבה המות, אילו לא היה העול היה מת בסיבה אחרת

Death is the act of God; the killing is the act of the wrongdoer. B was meant to die anyway, and would have died some other way. A is punished because he chose to commit murder.

וכן השאלה על הגנב... האבוד מעשה הבורא והגניבה מעשה האדם, וכאשר חייבה החכמה אבוד הדבר ההוא, אילו לא היה גונב היה אבד בפנים אחרים

If A steals a hundred pounds from B, B was going to lose a hundred pounds anyway: an extra fine, money dropped in the street, "whatever it may be." A is punished because he should not have taken it.

"I don't think one can doubt this." For Saadia, our free will extends only as far as what Hakadosh Baruch Hu has decreed. And it works both ways. You see a homeless man and give him a hundred pounds for a night in a hotel. According to Saadia, he would somehow have found a room anyway. You are rewarded because it came about through you. "What that means is it quite limits our potential of our actions."

The second approach: free will can change the outcome

"Many disagree with this... and I prefer the second approach much more, because it gives us much more free will."

The Malbim on David and Gad. When offered a choice of punishments, David said:

צר לי מאד, נפלה נא ביד ה' כי רבים רחמיו, וביד אדם אל אפלה

Let me fall into the hand of Hashem, for His mercy is great, but not into the hand of man. The Malbim explains: famine is a natural punishment that comes from Hashem, but the sword of enemies depends on **בחירה**, their free will. So David chose the punishment that is in Hashem's direct providence, where His mercy can intervene. In human hands, "we don't know what can happen." Although Hashem decrees things upon us for good or bad, other human beings have the ability to change them.

The Or HaChaim on Yosef and the pit. From Parashat Vayeshev, a couple of weeks earlier. The brothers said:

לכו ונהרגהו ונשלכהו באחד הברות ואמרנו חיה רעה אכלתהו, ונראה מה יהיו חלמתיו

The Or HaChaim explains their reasoning. Yosef dreamt he would be a leader. If we manage to kill him, that proves his dreams were false, and a false dreamer is *chayav mitah*. So killing him would retroactively prove we were right to. "A very elegant solution."

Then Reuven says, **לא נכנו נפש... השליכו אתו אל הבור הזה... ויד אל תשלחו בו**. What is the difference, if he will die in the pit anyway? The simple answer is that Reuven planned to come back and save him. But the Or HaChaim says:

לפי שהאדם בעל בחירה ורצון, ויכול להרוג מי שלא נתחייב מיתה, מה שאין כן חיות רעות לא יפגעו באדם אם לא יתחייב מיתה לשמים

Because a person has free choice, he can kill someone who was not sentenced to death. Wild animals, however, will not harm a person unless Heaven has decreed it. That is why the verse says **ויצלהו מידם**, from their hands, meaning from their free will. Reuven's answer refutes their test: Yosef might be a true

prophet, and they could still kill him, because free will can override the decree. So killing him would prove nothing.

"There's no words clearer than this." A person can be decreed on Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur to live the coming year: he will not die of famine or a car accident. "And then a wicked person comes in the middle of the year, says I don't like you, and goes and kills you."

The Rabbi added that the Zohar says the same, and that **Rabbi Tatz** has a book, *Free Will and Destiny*, with several chapters bringing many sources for this view. He tries to reinterpret Saadia too, "I think it's very difficult. I think Saadia is very clear."

Why it matters

	Saadia	The Malbim, Or HaChaim, Zohar
Can I harm someone Hashem has not decreed?	No. It would have happened anyway	Yes. Free will can go against the decree
Can I help someone beyond his decree?	It would have happened anyway; I am rewarded because it came through me	Yes. If Hashem decreed poverty on him, and I help him, I have changed it
What our actions mean	We are the channel	We are "actually changing the world"

"I prefer the second approach because it gives us much more autonomy... when we do good we're doing good and we're actually changing the world, because without us the world wouldn't be the same."

Mark's question

Mark noted that in the first approach you still have free will: Hashem gives you the opportunity by putting you on that road past the homeless man, and you choose whether to give or walk past. "Correct." In the first approach, if you don't help, someone else will; he will somehow find money for a room. In the second, "if I decide not to help this person, he'll stay there."

Chapter 14: Wisdom (*Chochmah*)

Their argument

מתלמידי החכמים יש אומרים שאין ראוי לאדם להתעסק בעולם הזה בדבר חוץ מבקשת החכמה

Some scholars say a person should do nothing in this world except pursue wisdom. As the chapter makes clear, Saadia means both Torah wisdom and the sciences.

- Through it one comes to understand the elements and their mixtures, nature and science, and to know the Creator, the heavens and the power of the spheres: astronomy and theology.
- It is sweet and pleasant to the soul: **ודעת לנפשך ינעם**.
- It heals the soul of foolishness: **רפאות תהי לשרך**.
- It nourishes like food: **ושקוי לעצמותיך**.
- It is like crystal and pearls on kings: **כי לוית חן הם לראשך וענקים לגרגרתיך**.
- One who does not understand it is as if not a human being: **כי לא יבינו אל פעלת ה' ואל מעשה ידיו**.

Saadia: all true, but not alone

ומצאתי כל מה שאמרו אמת, אבל מקום הטעות בו מה שאמרו שלא יתעסקו בדבר זולתה

"There's nothing like the pursuit of wisdom." The mistake is saying there is nothing else.

1. Who will feed and house you? Wisdom alone does not sustain a person. If he does not provide food, shelter and covering, what then? "Study, and let others fork out for you?"

ואם ישליך את עצמו בצרכו על אנשים אחרים, היה נבזה ואין סומכין עליו ולא מקבלים דבריו

If he throws himself on others for his needs, he is despised, no one relies on him and no one accepts his words. "And unfortunately I think we sometimes see this." Of course someone who studies all day, supported by others, will gain great knowledge. "Problem is no one's going to accept that intellect, that wisdom from you, because you are needy for them." As Kohelet says, **וחכמת המסכן בזויה ודבריו אינם נשמעים**.

2. Living on dry bread does not work either. If he says he will not rely on others and will live on the barest scraps, the refinement and subtlety of his wisdom will be lost. To focus, analyse and grasp properly, a person needs decent food and a decent home, everything in place: **תפוחי זהב במשכיות כסף, דבר דבר על אפניו**.

The man and the Levi'im

Saadia brings two proofs that Hashem provides for those devoted to wisdom:

- **The man in the wilderness.** Hashem fed Bnei Yisrael with fine food so that they could devote themselves to wisdom: **ויצא העם ולקטו דבר יום ביומו למען אנסנו הילך בתורתי אם לא**. The Rabbi noted that this is not the literal meaning, which is about the test of gathering only one day's portion. Saadia reads it as: I am sustaining them so that, free of distraction, they can study My Torah.
- **The Levi'im's tithe.** Levi was one of thirteen tribes, yet received a tenth of the produce of all the others, **כדי שיהיה מזונם ריוח**, so that their sustenance would be ample. "When I read this I was fascinated. I've never thought about this." By default they were getting more than everyone else, more than an equal share, so that they would have no worries and could study and teach, which was their duty. A participant added that since the Levi'im were a small tribe, they received even more per head; the Rabbi agreed, though Saadia does not say it.

3. If everyone did it. If everyone agreed with this group, there would be no children and no marriage. And if people studied only one kind of wisdom, Torah alone or science alone, the other would be lost. Saadia says the love of worldly knowledge was planted in us to serve as a help to this work, to know **קשט אמרי אמת**.

The Rabbi's conclusion

"Of course, pursuit of chochmah is fantastic, but it should not come at the expense of a person's basic necessities." There is nothing like people who dedicate themselves to Torah study all day: "that's an incredible thing, and may we merit to be part of those kinds of people." But it has to come with a plan for how they will look after themselves and those who rely on them.

Chapter 15: Worship (*Avodah*)

Their argument

ימצאו אנשים רבים שאומרים כי הטוב שיתעסק בו האדם בעולם הזה עבודת אלהיו בלבד

Many say the best thing is to serve Hashem and nothing else: fast by day, rise at night to praise and thank Him (the Rabbi mentioned *tikkun chatzot* and Tehillim), and leave all the affairs of this world, because Hashem will provide the food and needs of one who serves Him.

- Serving Him is a great delight: **כי נעים נאוה תהלה**, and **עבדו את ה' בשמחה**.
- The reward with the Creator is great: **וחמלתי עליהם כאשר יחמל איש על בנו העבד אתו**.

Saadia: true, but not alone

כל מה שסיפרו בעבודת הבורא אמת וברור... אך מקום טעותם היה התבודדותם לבדם

You cannot praise Hashem enough: **גדול ה' ומהלל מאד ולגדלתו אין חקר**. The mistake is isolating it and saying a person needs nothing else.

1. Without food the body cannot survive, and without marriage and children, service of Hashem itself will not continue. If one generation all did this, they would die and worship would die with them. Service is meant for fathers, sons and grandsons: **למען תירא את ה' אלהיך... אתה ובנך ובן בנך כל ימי חייך**. "Judaism is about the family, it's about the generations, it's about passing it on."

2. The hermit cannot keep most of the Torah. Saadia recalls his distinction, from the essay on the mitzvot, between **מצוות שכליות**, rational commandments, and **מצוות שמעיות**, revealed commandments. Service of Hashem means all of them. How can a recluse keep:

- the mitzvot of honest weights and measures? "But I don't do business, because I just spend the whole day saying Tehillim."
- the mitzvot of justice, **לא תטה משפט לא תכיר פנים**? "I don't go to courts. I've nothing to do with this world."
- the laws of forbidden and permitted, pure and impure, **להבדיל בין הטמא ובין הטהור**?
- the mitzvot of the field, tithes and charity? "But I don't have a field, because all I do is pray to God the whole day."

If he answers that others will do business and run the courts, then **הם עובדים ולא הוא**: they are the ones serving, **כי בהם נשלמה עבודת הבורא ולא בו**.

The Rabbi drew out a principle: "A system cannot be correct... which is only right for some people but not everyone." Some people are more attuned to certain things. But if this is presented as the way to serve Hashem, then everyone should aspire to it, and then who will keep the rest of the Torah?

3. Trust in Hashem works through causes.

והוא ששמו יתברך שם לכל דבר סיבה ומנהג קבוע שצריך שיבוקש מהפנים ההם

Their trust is right, but they forget that Hashem has given everything a cause and a fixed order through which it must be sought. "You cannot just sit back and expect the food, the money, to arrive on you."

If they say that trust covers everything, then **יבטחו עליו בשכר העבודה גם כן, שיגמל גמולו בלא עבודה**: let them also trust Him to reward them without any service at all. If that is unreasonable, because service is the cause of reward, then the same applies to sustenance, which has its causes too. Sometimes Hashem

does do things by sign and wonder, without a prior cause, but He does not make it a regular practice to change the nature He placed in the world.

Chapter 16: Rest (*Menuchah*)

Their argument

אמרו אנשים כי המנוחה טובה מכל מה שיבקש האדם בעולם הזה

The thirteenth group says the best thing in life is rest. "The longer you can sleep, the longer you can stay in bed, the longer you can stay on your sunbed, that's the best life."

- It heals the soul and removes the body's weariness.
- The harder a person works, the more he longs for rest. "How often do we crash on our beds at the end of the week and Shabbat."
- Kings rest more than anyone; if it were not good, they would not choose it.
- It relaxes the body, improves sleep and digestion and purifies the blood.
- The Torah praises it, **ומצאו מרגוע לנפשתיכם**, and commands rest on Shabbat and the festivals, so surely the whole week should be like that.

Saadia: they are foolish

כי המנוחה לא תשלם לאדם אלא אחר השגחה גדולה ותיקון צרכיו והכנת כל אודותיו, ואחר כך ינוח וישקוט

True rest only comes after a person has worked hard and arranged all his needs. **הכן בחוץ מלאכתך ועתדה בשדה לך, אחר ובנית ביתך**.

אבל המנוחה לבדה מבלתי דבר מעליה... ענין עצלה

Rest by itself, with nothing before it, is not rest. It is **עצלה**, laziness.

Menuchah versus *atzlah*

The Rabbi gave an analogy. Someone can say, "I want to rest and sit in the sauna the whole day." That's laziness. But when someone has worked hard, done a lot of exercise, and his body feels weak from exertion, and then he sits and relaxes, "ah, and that's something else. Then you feel your body's being revived. That's *menuchah*."

What laziness does

כי האדם כשתלוהו העצלה יבוא רשו ויחסר כל טוב

- **Poverty.** "If it's not your generation, it'll be your children, or your grandchildren." Like the man who buys homes for his great-grandchildren: "there's going to come a time when that wealth runs out." **מעט שנות מעט תנומות מעט חבק ידים לשכב, ובא כמהלך רישך ומחסרך כאיש מגן**.
- **Sadness.** He cannot prepare food or provide shelter, and lives in grief, remembering the rest he craved: **תאות עצל תמיתנו כי מאנו ידיו לעשות**.
- **Losing the mitzvot.** He ends up abandoning prayer, fasting, Torah and mitzvot.
- **Laziness is linked to wickedness,** and its opposite is righteousness: **כל היום התאוה תאוה, וצדיק יתן ולא יחשך**.
- **Illness.** Heaviness, bloating, weakness, and conditions of the legs, including varicose veins, kidney trouble and **חולי הפיל**. The Rabbi explained that the English translation calls this "Barbados leg," a

swelling of the leg like an elephant's (*pil* is Hebrew for elephant).

The Torah itself says **ששת ימים תעבד ועשית כל מלאכתך, וביום השביעי תשבת**: work, then rest.

אפילו מי שסיפקו אחרים אינו ראוי לבטלה

Even someone who is fully provided for should not be idle: **צופיה הליכות ביתה ולחם עצלות לא תאכל**. The Eshet Chayil works even when she has everything.

When rest is right

Saadia says the soul's love of rest was given so that it would long for the tranquility the Creator has prepared for it in the World to Come: **והיה מעשה הצדקה שלום ועבדת הצדקה השקט ובטח עד עולם, וישב עמי בנוה שלום**. The Rabbi added the Gemara: **Shabbat is one sixtieth of Olam HaBa**, a taste of the rest to come.

Chapter 17: The Right Combination

The Rabbi listed all thirteen once more: abstinence, eating, intimacy, passion, wealth, children, building, long life, power, revenge, wisdom, worship and rest. "Each one has many benefits." Even revenge has its place, in punishing those who do wrong.

Each alone fails

שכל מי שרוצה להתנהג באחד משלשה עשר האלו לבדו... יעוות לו חפצו ויקצר מלהגיע מה שאוהב

Anyone who takes one of these alone, enjoying only it and abandoning the rest, will find his goal twisted and fall short of what he wants. As Chapter 3 said from Kohelet, anything crooked is deficient.

אבל כשיתקבצו הענינים האלה כולם, הוא הנכוחה הגמורה

When they are combined, that is the complete right path.

Not equal shares

ואין ראוי גם כן שיקח מכל אחד מהם חלק השוה בשוה, אלא יקח מכל מין מהם השיעור אשר הוא ראוי לקחת כפי מה שתחייב החכמה והתורה

He should not take an equal share of each, but the amount each deserves, as wisdom and Torah require. The Rabbi: at different periods of life a person needs more of one thing, more study at one time, more focus on career, on money and the future, at another. "Different times, different things, but you need a combination."

Saadia's portrait of the balanced person

- **Food, drink and intimacy:** he takes what he needs to live and to have children, and enjoys what is permitted.
- **Excess:** when he wants more than is right, or to take from others, he stops himself.
- **When he cannot stop: ישלח בה מדת הפרישות**, he sends out abstinence until he loathes it. The Rabbi saw here the Rambam's idea: if you feel yourself falling into something, you must become stronger against it, and perhaps bend back and cut down even on permitted things.
- **Money and children:** he looks after what the Creator has graciously given him, according to his love for them.
- **The land:** he works it as he needs.

- **Temptation at work:** if desire pushes him to do something forbidden, he brings out abstinence.
- **This world for the next:** he lives in this world for the sake of the World to Come, recognising it is the vestibule and the preparation for Olam HaBa.
- **Power and revenge:** he does not seek them. If authority falls into his lap, he accepts it to uphold the laws of the Torah and justice among people.
- **Rest and laziness:** he keeps away from laziness entirely.
- **Free time:** whatever time remains after earning his living, he devotes to **העבודה והחכמה**, prayer and study, Torah and science.

יהיה משובח בשני העולמות

Then he will be praised in both worlds: **מכל משמר נצר לבך כי ממנו תוצאות חיים**.

Like a compound medicine

Saadia compares this to bodies compounded of the elements, and to medicine. A prescription takes three *zuz* of one ingredient, four *gerah* of another, half a *zuz* of another, half a *gerah* or an *issar* of another. **לא יתכן שיקח מכל אחד משקל שוה**: you would never give all ingredients in equal weight. **כן הענין באלו המדות**: so with these traits.

Summary

1. **Free will and decree:** Saadia holds that no one can harm or help a person beyond what Hashem decreed; the doer is judged because it came through him. The Malbim (David's choice of famine over the sword), the Or HaChaim (Reuven and the pit) and the Zohar hold that free will can override the decree. The Rabbi prefers the second: our actions really change the world.
2. **Wisdom:** nothing compares to it, but it cannot replace earning a living. Relying on others makes a scholar's words unheeded; living on scraps dulls his mind. Hashem fed Israel with man and gave the Levi'im a generous tithe so they could study.
3. **Worship:** true, but a recluse cannot keep the Torah's mitzvot of business, justice and the field, and cannot pass it on to children. Trust in Hashem works through causes, just as reward comes through service.
4. **Rest:** *menuchah* follows work; without work it is *atzlah*, laziness, which leads to poverty, sadness, sin and illness. Rest is a taste of the World to Come.
5. **The combination:** all thirteen, each in the measure wisdom and Torah require, like a compound medicine. Then a person is praised in both worlds.

Coming Up

- **Next week, 6:00 pm:** in person at Tiferet Hall for those in London, and on Zoom. Chapters 18 and 19, on sight, hearing, smell and music, read together with the English, and a mini siyum.
- **The week after:** a summary of the whole sefer and a discussion of the next one: the Moreh Nevuchim, the Kuzari or HaMaspik. Suggestions welcome. The class began Saadia two years ago, after finishing Da'at Tevunot.
- **This week:** the Tuesday Rambam shiur and Thursday Hilchot Shabbat continue.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/TbVGJLw8cvo · More shiurim: rabbikada.com